ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Paper 1123/11
Composition

General Comments:

The overall standard of work this year seemed to be well up to that of previous years. The narrative questions in **Part 1** were, as always, more popular than the others but there was a greater interest in the descriptive and discursive titles than in previous years. This year, **Part 2** was done confidently as an exercise but there was some difficulty in addressing one of the Content points. This report will elaborate on approaches to this part of the examination. The vast majority of candidates used the time well and rubric infringements were few. The length of essays was generally appropriate and there were fewer examples of lengthy drafts which were then copied word for word. The use of correcting fluid continues to pose less of a problem than it used to. The strengths and weaknesses of the linguistic ability were very much those which have featured in previous reports: there was much lively, dramatic, engaging writing by very many candidates whereas some candidates would benefit from avoiding inconsistency of tenses and faulty agreement. Fewer prepared openings to essays were used and this worked to the benefit of candidates. A number of candidates would be helped by writing shorter essays within the word limits as the main task of this exam is to demonstrate linguistic and organisational skills rather than to show ingenuity in the content. It is however always a pleasure to be able to pay tribute to the extremely high standard of work at the top end of the range which continues to impress with little evidence of second language errors.

Comments on specific questions:

Part 1

Question 1 Describe the sights, sounds, tastes and smells of the busiest street in your area.

This was intended, as the first question often is, to be a descriptive essay which would allow an opportunity to those candidates who could create atmosphere, setting, and character etc. This particular question was a popular one and there were plenty of lively answers as candidates spoke directly from personal experience about a place that they felt strongly about and knew a great deal about. This led to some engaging descriptions, which tried to persuade the reader about the merits or de-merits of the place. The stronger candidates covered all of the senses fully and became quite creative in attempting to evoke the atmosphere for the reader, using similes and metaphors to make their descriptions more vivid. Colours were very well used as were the cries of the various sellers. The smells and tastes of food were evoked with great enjoyment by the majority of candidates. Contrast was a very effective method of describing the scene and many candidates were excellent at illustrating both the rich and the poor shoppers, the early and the late activities as well as the individual sellers and the big businesses. Adjectives, carefully chosen, were a very positive feature as one would expect in descriptive essays. Some candidates, perhaps those who did not live in big cities, offered equally successful descriptions of rural communities with busy market areas. There were some essays which were more limited because the candidate wrote a 'list' type description which moved far too quickly from one aspect of the scene to another. In descriptive essays of this sort it is usually better to give some depth of detail to each aspect mentioned even if it means leaving out something else about the location. A number of candidates needed to take a more descriptive approach as they had given their answer too much of a narrative base – it was more about what they themselves did in the busy street. Similarly, there were a number of unbalanced essays where the venue was described but only some of the senses were evoked and it did prove the need to consider all of rather than just a part of the question.

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Question 2 Is the behaviour of people in your neighbourhood better or worse than it used to be? Give reasons and examples to support your view.

This was a popular question because it was so close to personal experience. It produced some well-argued cases and answers which described the deterioration of a neighbourhood into a violent area where armed robbery, murder and other crimes seemed to be the order of the day. H.I.V., drugs and violence were seen as everyday occurrences and both parents and teenagers themselves were blamed in equal measure. Other answers described the reverse situation where neighbourhoods had been turned around with improved education, more jobs and better infrastructure all making peoples' lives better. Such discursive topics benefit from being considered from both sides and this time stronger candidates made a clear distinction between the past and current situation in their neighbourhood and described reasons for the change in detail. Weaker answers confused the timing of good and bad aspects and did not always say whether things had changed. Some candidates were attracted by the personal nature of the topic and clearly felt strongly about lots of issues but they did not have the range of examples for this topic and thus produced repetitive ideas. It proved how important it is to plan a discursive essay to ensure that there are enough ideas to complete a worthwhile discussion without repetition. The question directly requested reasons and examples to add to the text and some candidates would have done well to take this opportunity so as to add a convincing edge to their beliefs.

Question 3 Write a story which includes the words: 'It was just as well she decided to change her appearance..'.

The responses were generally lively, interesting and often moving. There were lots of stories involving winning a school prom by being slimmer or more glamorous, or merely slimming for health reasons or someone changing their appearance when they were out of line with a peer group. These were all perfectly satisfactory responses. Most candidates took the opportunity to finish off the essay with a moral about the power of the change and the strength of mind it had taken. At their best such essays were marked by a high level of characterisation. The reader was given details of the struggle within a character when faced with the dilemma of having to change or not. In good essays there was useful background detail supplied, such as the details of the opposing or supportive views of friends or parents to the change. Less successful essays dealt in stereotypical characters and unrealistic detail with, for example, people suddenly winning the lottery and/or being transformed overnight. It is worth remembering that this is a test of language and does not need to rely on sensationalism. This title, as well as **Question 5**, proved how effective direct speech can be in providing character but only, of course, when it is properly punctuated and used sparingly. Some candidates could have been a bit more precise in their interpretation of the word "appearance". They took this to mean 'behaviour', 'character', 'attitude' or 'mood' – perhaps how you appear to others in a metaphorical sense rather than a literal sense. This was particularly true of stories about an unexpected and unwanted guest turning up at a party. There were also examples of a long, unrelated narrative, and the insertion of the sentence 'It was just as well…' at the end was rarely successful. 'Just as well' sometimes did not get the implication that something else might have happened if she had not decided to change her appearance.

Question 4 Gossip.

This topic proved less popular, even though with short titles such as these any approach is invited. Some did attempt a narrative title from personal experience about people who were gossips and they produced successful and engaging answers. Invariably, the gossips were dangerous people who damaged reputations and either did or did not suffer as a result. Occasionally there were examples of gossip that did some good because it highlighted a situation that led to the rescue of someone. The narrative approach succeeded whereas some candidates attempted a discursive approach and investigated the difference between 'good' and 'bad' gossip; not many were well-structured and they lacked a certain balance; weaker answers had fewer ideas and answers therefore became repetitive.

Question 5 Write about an occasion when someone had a sleepless night.

This proved an accessible, well-understood question and it allowed candidates to use expressive language to describe emotions and dramatic events. They could speak from personal experience or become creative in thinking up a likely scenario. The best answers gave lots of detail about not being able to sleep including "tossing, turning, rolling over and sweating". Some had invented dramatic narratives such as people being kidnapped which led to a sleepless night. Some told of relatives who had moved country and who could not cope with the temptation of drugs. Others chose the night before an exam where they spent the night worrying about the exam ahead. There were also stories of people having sleepless nights when they realised they were adopted. The best essays certainly did contain some very accurate characterisation as

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candidates outlined the fluctuating emotions of the person concerned. Unfortunately there were also several essays where the candidate wrote about a barely related topic and at the end the sleepless night was only tenuously linked to the narrative which preceded it. In such circumstances it is very difficult to write a convincing narrative with the depth of tension that this title required.

Part 2

In **Part 2**, candidates were asked to imagine or remember when accidents had taken place in their school. At the request of the Principal they had to write a report into the accidents. There was a further request to include suggestions on how to improve safety in the school. This was a scenario that was well within the experience of the vast majority of candidates who responded well to this task and many were able to gain all five Content points whilst the majority managed to gain at least three. The scenario allowed for a wide variety of causes for the accidents and suggestions for improvement.

As is always said with this question, **Part 2** is directed writing and so is more of a reading task than **Part 1**. Candidates had to be aware that in order to satisfy the requirements of the bullet points this year a perfect answer had to have:

- the names of two candidates who had been involved in accidents in the school;
- precise details of these accidents and it had to be more than one accident;
- other dangers that the candidates had noticed at school;
- a clear indication of the improvements that could be made to the school;
- a clear indication as to how candidates could be made more aware of keeping safe in school.

Where candidates failed to gain the Content points they were usually guilty of simply omitting the point or misreading the question or the scenario. It is vital to remember in this task that it is partly testing whether a candidate can follow instructions as they would do in factual writing in later life. In the first bullet point it was essential to mention two names and not just one as some did. The names of the candidates could be first or second names or both. Occasionally, candidates forgot to mention the candidates by name and simply left it at 'two candidates' or 'two members of 4b' and so lost the mark as the Principal would have been no wiser. There is room for some creativity in **Part 2** but with Content points candidates must answer what they are asked. Bullet point 2 asked for 'accidents' in the plural and careful reading of the question should have ensured this although many assumed that only one would do. Popular answers included broken water pipes and slippery floors, broken window glass, faulty furniture breaking in use, and various traffic problems in the school grounds. Some candidates misinterpreted 'accidents' as 'incidents', usually 'fights', and there were rather too many descriptions of *deliberate* confrontations whereas the whole point was that they should be accidental. This in turn also made the first point rather suspect as the two named candidates were perpetrators rather than victims. The third Content point should have been straightforward and was for the vast majority who mentioned alternative dangers such as snakes in the grounds but some did mention the same dangers as they had mentioned in bullet 2 and so did not gain the point. There was great variety in the detail given for the fourth bullet point. Most improvements, such as new furniture, new traffic controls, renewed windows and properly cleaned floor areas were related to the accidents already mentioned but some were new and included the rebuilding of toilets or refurbishing of workrooms and laboratories. The final bullet point was usually gained well enough with new, improved signs and reinforced rules being the favourite means. As far as tone was concerned, candidates needed to accept the Principal was in charge of this and not, as some did, *demand* that something be done.

Overall, the vast majority wrote a suitable amount for **Part 2** and captured the polite, accurate, helpful tone and approach very well. Where many candidates scored more heavily than others was in the use of the correct format. If a report is asked for, candidates could write a letter or a formal report but not mix the two as some did by starting as a report and then ending with a letter valediction. It is very pleasing to be able to say again this year that more and more candidates paragraphed their directed writing along the lines of the bullet points but equally there were a number who would do well to implement this skill.

Guidance for teachers preparing candidates for future examinations:

- In **Part 1** tasks, essays asking candidates 'To describe...' should not be attempted unless the candidate is prepared to demonstrate that skill.
- Letter headings are not required in **Part 2** unless specifically requested.
- The proper punctuation and layout of speech can give problems and a greater focus on this would pay dividends.

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- Continued work on correct tenses would benefit the majority of candidates.
- Candidates should avoid clichéd essay openings such as 'It all happened/began...' or 'I still remember…'.
- Candidates should be clear about the difference between and appropriate use of 'his' and 'her' and the verbs ask/say/tell.
- Candidates should remember to choose appropriate vocabulary for the audience and task. For example, the use of expletives is unlikely to be acceptable in the examination context.

Final Comment:

There is a very great deal of excellent expression and vocabulary amongst the candidates who take this examination. The best writing this year was really was of a very high standard indeed, which is a tribute to the hard work of both candidates and teachers.

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ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Paper 1123/12
Composition

General Comments:

Once again, the overall standard of work this year seemed to be well up to that of previous years. The narrative questions in **Part 1** were, as always, more popular than the others but there was a greater interest in the descriptive and discursive titles than in recent years. This year, **Part 2** was done more confidently than previously and an improvement was seen overall in addressing the Content points. This report will elaborate on approaches to this part of the examination. The vast majority of candidates used the time well and rubric infringements were few. The length of essays was generally appropriate and there were fewer examples of lengthy first drafts which were then copied word for word. The use of correcting fluid also posed less of a problem than it used to. The strengths and weaknesses of the linguistic ability were very much those which have featured in previous reports: there was much lively, dramatic, engaging writing by very many candidates whereas some candidates would benefit from avoiding serious problems with the inconsistency of tenses and faulty agreement. Fewer prepared openings to essays were used and this worked to the benefit of candidates. A number of candidates would be helped by writing shorter essays within the word limits as the main task of this exam is to demonstrate linguistic and organisational skills rather than to show ingenuity in the content. It is however always a pleasure to be able to pay tribute to the extremely high standard of work of the best candidates which continues to impress with little evidence of second language errors.

Comments on specific questions:

Part 1

Question 1 Describe your favourite place of entertainment and write about some of the people who work there.

This was quite a popular choice of question and done very well by a large number of candidates. It was intended, as the first question often is, to be a descriptive essay which would allow an opportunity to those candidates who could create atmosphere, setting, and character etc. and it is true that there were very many successful attempts. The choice of venue was important and the best answers came when the choice was a specific place rather than just any beach or any picnic or activity, so games arcades, the botanical gardens, market places, shopping malls, discos, 'nite clubs' and cafes provided suitable locations to describe and emphasise 'entertainment'. Some candidates suggested more unlikely venues such as school, library and even hospitals and these proved more difficult to suggest 'entertainment'. Some venues, such as a sugar-refining plant, were clearly places of interest rather than 'entertainment' and so were more difficult to write about at length. Adjectives, carefully chosen, were a very positive feature of the best work as one would expect in descriptive essays. A number of candidates needed to take a more descriptive approach as they had given their answer too much of a narrative base – they were more like stories of a trip or a holiday. Similarly, there were a number of unbalanced essays where the venue was described but the workers gained only a cursory mention as to their task and it did prove the need to consider all of, rather than just a part of, the question.

Question 2 Is it worse to have too little money or too much? Give reasons and examples to support your view.

This topic produced more responses than were expected and may have attracted a number of candidates studying Economics or Accounts; certainly there was a good use of financial terms by many. Examiners commented that there were very many sensible and interesting arguments and what was particularly striking was the balanced nature of much of the argument. Candidates are clearly learning that being aware of both sides of a debate will not only impress as a rational approach but will, in practical terms, provide much more material and so avoid the greatest pitfall of discursive essays, the repetition of ideas. A few candidates

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tended to repeat thoughts and it proved how important it is to plan a discursive essay to ensure that there are enough ideas to complete a worthwhile discussion without repetition. This was overcome very well by those candidates who had good stories and evidence to support their views. Some candidates were led into generalisation a little, assuming that anyone with too little money was led into crime and those with too much were invariably arrogant and/or alcoholic but overall most candidates did a good job of illustrating the pitfalls of either extreme and came to the conclusion that a comfortable amount of money, sufficient to cover wants and needs, was probably the best outcome in life. One path to avoid in such an essay is too much repetition of the key word(s) from the title and in this case the finding of ways to avoid saying 'money' too often invariably helped.

Question 3 Write about an occasion when someone made a great sacrifice to keep a best friend.

This essay was the second most popular of the questions set, after **Question 5**. The responses were generally lively, interesting and often touching. There were lots of stories involving giving up a university place abroad, giving up a girlfriend/boyfriend, or about donating one or more vital organs to a friend in need. Taking the blame in school when someone else was guilty of a misdemeanour was a common topic. These were all perfectly satisfactory responses. Some candidates could have been a bit more precise as some misinterpreted the mere doing of a favour, helping or giving encouragement as 'sacrifice' and these lacked the necessary tension provided by the better narratives. Most candidates took the opportunity to finish off the essay with a comfortable moral about the power of friendship or sacrifice. At their best, such essays were marked by a high level of characterisation. The reader was given details of the struggle within a character when faced with the dilemma of having to sacrifice or not. In good essays there was useful background detail supplied, such as the harrowing details of an accident which led to organ transplant or the poverty which required a financial donation by one friend to another, either for study or an operation. Less successful essays dealt in stereotypical characters and unrealistic detail with, for example, a narrator prepared to donate both eyes, or even his/her heart, to a deserving friend. It is worth remembering that this is a test of language and does not need to rely on sensationalism. This title, as well as **Question 5**, proved how effective direct speech can be in providing character but only, of course, when it is properly punctuated and used sparingly.

Question 4 Silence.

This was an unpopular title and the vast majority chose to ignore it, even though with short titles such as these any approach is invited. Some did attempt a narrative title about people who were silent for a reason and some wrote about places that were havens of peace. Some wrote stories about situations when silence was necessary if not vital. Discursive approaches which listed occasions when silence was beneficial and explained why tended to be a little more limited. If a discursive approach is to be taken, it is essential that the candidate has a lot to say and can push the text into a new area, paragraph by paragraph; if not, the essay become a mere list which it is better to avoid. Connectives such as 'Moreover' and 'Furthermore' are very useful but only if they genuinely further the argument rather than attempt to disguise a mere repetition of information.

Question 5 Write a story which includes the words: 'Right! That's it! You have been late too often'.

This was easily the most popular question, probably because of its closeness to personal experience; it was a title which fitted both school and business locations and offered endless possibilities for those seeking to be creative. Mostly there were stories of getting up late in the morning or a traffic hold up or crash on the way to school or work which resulted in lateness. Sometimes it was more a personality trait of the narrator to be late for events and this was never worse than in many stories where someone was due to get engaged or married and turned up late for the ceremony to find that the patience of the other party had worn thin. Good characterisation, setting, vocabulary and varied sentence structure marked out the better scripts as always. This particular question gave rise to some excellent use of the flashback technique when the lateness was highlighted at the beginning of the essay and then the reader was taken back to see example of previous such occasions. On the other hand, weaker scripts treated the idea of lateness as a bolt on to a familiar story so that there was a very thin connection to the given sentence in the title. Quite often, weaker candidates indulged in a long drawn out build up to a far too rapid denouement. Linguistically, the confident use of tenses and the ability to build to a climax so that the given sentence did truly seem devastating were considerable advantages.

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Part 2

In **Part 2**, candidates were asked to imagine or remember an occasion when they witnessed a noisy argument between two rival candidates queuing for food in the school canteen. At the request of the Principal they had to write an account of the incident. This was a scenario that was well within the experience of the vast majority of candidates who responded extremely well to this task and were able to gain all five Content points very easily whilst the majority managed to gain at least four. The scenario allowed for a wide variety of reasons for the argument and the rivalry and this contributed greatly to the success and interest of the responses.

As is always said with this question, **Part 2** is directed writing and so is more of a reading task than **Part 1**. Candidates had to be aware that in order to satisfy the requirements of the bullet points this year a perfect answer had to have:

- a clear indication of the date of the event **and** the names of both candidates;
- precise details about what started the argument, what was the flashpoint;
- details of how the incident continued, however briefly;
- a clear indication of why the candidates disliked each other in the first place;
- the writer's suggestion about what should happen to the two candidates.

Where candidates failed to gain the Content points they were usually guilty of simply omitting the point or misreading the question or the scenario. It is vital to remember in this task that it is partly testing whether a candidate can follow instructions as they would do in factual writing in later life. In the first bullet point it was essential to mention the date of the incident, not just date the report. This could be done by putting an actual date in the text or referring to 'last Tuesday' if the account had been dated. Something as vague as 'it was a Monday..' simply did not help the Principal enough. The names of the candidates could be first or second names or both. Occasionally, candidates forgot to mention the candidates by name and simply left it at 'two candidates' and so lost the mark as the Principal would have been no wiser. Some had one candidate arguing with the chef or the canteen manager and again lost the mark.

There is room for some creativity in **Part 2** but with Content points candidates must answer what they are asked. There were many reasons for the argument because invention was welcome here. The most popular reasons were queue-jumping, pushing in the queue, and both candidates wanting the same item of food when there was only one left and then it was a matter of who came first. More unusual reasons involved putting chewing gum in someone's hair, and finding money on the floor. The third Content point should have been straightforward as it only needed the argument to move on in some way. Most candidates ensured this point by saying 'Then..' or '..the fight continued...' and so there was no doubt. However some candidates elaborated the initial flashpoint a little too much and assumed this was good enough for the continuation whereas it left doubt in the Examiner's mind. It is far better with the bullet points to leave the reader in no doubt. This was certainly the case with a significant number of candidates who included a considerable amount of violence in the two points and suggested that some other candidates were gaining great amusement from the incident!

There was great variety in the detail given for the fourth bullet point. Although they had often been friends in the first place, the two candidates disliked each other now because they competed in academic and/or sporting areas, or they were fighting over a girlfriend or boyfriend, or their families were rivals in business. Whatever the reason, it was accepted even though the answers were sometimes a little long and took away time that could have been spent on the third bullet point. Some candidates would have done better to remember the timescale implied – the candidates had 'always' been rivals and saying that they broke their friendship the week before was a bit short. Sometimes vagueness was a problem; candidates need to remember to be precise and simply saying 'family problems' did not really spell out the problem well enough. Again, a lack of precision was a problem if candidates said that the dislike was only on one side even though the bullet point suggested otherwise. Careful consideration needed to be given to the correct tense here. Some said they 'had' always disliked each other whereas in fact they still did. In the last bullet point there were some severe corporal punishments suggested by the minority and equally some very liberal 'punishments' but in the main it was a matter of a detention or a talking to by the Principal or a matter of calling in the parents. Expulsion was more serious but in fact any suggestion was acceptable as long as it was something in the future whereas some candidates mentioned what had already been done. As far as tone was concerned, candidates needed to accept the Principal was in charge of this and not, as some did, 'demand' that something be done to the two candidates.

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Overall, the vast majority wrote a suitable amount for **Part 2** and captured the polite, accurate, helpful tone and approach very well. Where many candidates scored more heavily than others was in the use of the correct format. If an account is called for, candidates can chose to write a letter **or** a report but they should not confuse the two as some did here by starting off in report mode and then ending with a letter valediction, sometimes an incorrect one. It is very pleasing to be able to say again this year that more and more candidates are paragraphing their directed writing along the lines of the bullet points but equally there were still a number who would do well to implement this skill.

Guidance for teachers preparing candidates for future examinations:

- Candidates should remember to choose appropriate vocabulary for the audience and task. For example, the use of expletives is unlikely to be acceptable in the examination context.
- In **Part 1** tasks, essays asking candidates 'To describe…' should not be attempted unless the candidate is prepared to demonstrate that skill.
- Letter headings are not required in **Part 2** unless specifically requested.
- The proper punctuation and layout of speech can give problems and a greater focus on this would pay dividends.
- Continued work on correct tenses would help the majority.
- Candidates should avoid clichéd essay openings such as 'It all happened/began...' or 'I still remember...'.

Final Comment:

Very large numbers of the candidates in all countries can feel justifiably proud of their performance in expressing themselves so accurately and this is a tribute to the ability and hard work of both candidates and teachers.

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